



Welcome to the Valley

A Curated First-Time Player Experience

2026-07-20

1 Setup: Installing SMAPI and Stardrop

This chapter walks through setting up Stardrop and SMAPI, the two tools you need to manage and run Stardew Valley mods. Stardrop is a purpose-built mod manager for Stardew Valley — lightweight, cross-platform, and designed to work seamlessly with SMAPI.

1.1 Prerequisites

- **Stardew Valley 1.6.15** (or latest) installed via Steam or GOG. Run it once before modding so the game generates its initial config files.
- **~2 GB free disk space** for the modlist.
- A free [Nexus Mods](#) account — almost every mod in this catalog is hosted there.

1.2 How This Guide Is Structured: The Three-Wave Approach

This guide teaches Stardew Valley in three waves. Each wave adds complexity — install each wave’s mods as a group, play with them until you’re comfortable, then move on. Installing everything at once will overwhelm you with mechanics you have no context for.

1.2.1 Wave 1 — Vanilla (Enhanced Quality of Life)

Play your first year (or more) with only **foundations, bugfixes, and UI/HUD mods** installed. The game looks cleaner, runs smoother, and surfaces information better — but every mechanic is pure Stardew Valley. Chapter [02-vanilla-primer.md](#) teaches all the core systems: farming, mining, fishing, combat, relationships, and the Community Center.

Wave 1 mod catalog sections: [00 — Foundations](#) · [01 — Bugfixes](#) · [02 — UI and HUD](#)

1.2.2 Wave 2 — Content Expansion

Once vanilla mechanics are second nature, add content mods. These introduce new areas, items, enemies, NPCs, and storylines — but the core game loop (farm → mine → craft → build relationships → repeat) stays intact. Chapter [04-modded-gameplay.md](#) section “Wave 2” teaches the new systems these mods bring.

Wave 2 mod catalog sections: [03–06 — Graphics](#) · [07 — World Expansion](#) · [08 — Monsters and Combat](#) · [09 — Items and Weapons](#) · [10 — NPC Interactions](#) · [11 — Grown-Up Town](#) · [15 — Music and Audio](#)

1.2.3 Wave 3 — Gameplay Overhaul

For players who have thoroughly explored Waves 1 and 2 and want deeper mechanical changes. These mods rework skill trees, profession paths, farming systems, and core gameplay balance. They assume you know the game intimately — rebalancing mods won’t make sense if you don’t know what they changed.

Wave 3 mod catalog sections: [12 — Gameplay Tweaks](#) · [13 — Skills and Professions](#) · [14 — Farming and Making](#)

1.3 Installing SMAPI

SMAPI (Stardew Modding API) is the loader that lets mods hook into the game. Without it, no mod works.

1. Go to smapi.io and download the installer for Windows.
2. Run the installer. It will ask where Stardew Valley is installed:
 - **Steam:** `C:\Program Files (x86)\Steam\steamapps\common\Stardew Valley`
 - **GOG:** `C:\Program Files (x86)\GOG Galaxy\Games\Stardew Valley`
 - **Game Pass:** The WindowsApps folder — use the “find my game” button in the installer.
3. The installer patches `StardewModdingAPI.exe` into your game folder and adds a “play with SMAPI” option to your Steam/GOG launcher.

To verify: run the game via SMAPI. You should see a dark console window open alongside the game with SMAPI version info. If you see that, SMAPI is working.

1.4 Installing Stardrop

Stardrop is an open-source, cross-platform mod manager built specifically for Stardew Valley. Unlike general-purpose mod managers, it integrates directly with SMAPI and the Nexus Mods API — no plugin configuration, no virtual file system to learn.

1. Download the latest release from [Stardrop on Nexus Mods](#) (or from the [GitHub releases page](#)).
2. Extract the archive to a folder of your choice. Example: `C:\Games\Stardrop`
3. Run `stardrop.exe`. On first launch it will ask for your Stardew Valley install folder — point it at your game directory.

1.4.1 First Launch

1. Stardrop scans your `Mods` folder and loads any existing mods. If you already installed SMAPI from the previous step, you will see it listed.
2. The main window shows a table of your mods with columns for name, version, status, and update availability.
3. Click **Help** → **Settings** to set up Nexus integration and choose your preferences.

1.4.2 Connect to Nexus Mods

1. In Stardrop, go to **Nexus Mods** → **API Connection** → **Stardrop**.
2. A browser window opens asking you to authorize Stardrop. Log in with your Nexus Mods account and grant access.
3. Copy the API key from the browser back into Stardrop and click **Apply**.
4. Once connected, the **Download with Mod Manager** button on Nexus mod pages will trigger Stardrop to download and install mods automatically.

1.4.3 Set Up a Profile

Stardrop supports mod profiles — separate mod lists for different playthroughs. Create one for this guide:

1. Click **Profiles** → **Manage Profiles**.
2. Click **New**, name it `SDV ModList Guide`, and click **OK**.
3. Check **Automatically save profile changes** so your mod list stays in sync.
4. Select this profile from the dropdown before installing mods.

1.5 Installing Mods

The mod catalog in [03-mod-catalog/](#) lists every mod in installation order. Install each category as a group before moving to the next.

1.5.1 Downloading from Nexus Mods

- Browse to the mod's Nexus page and click **Download with Mod Manager** (the "Vortex" button). Stardrop's NXM handler picks it up automatically.
- If the download doesn't start, check that your API key is valid in **Nexus Mods** → **API Connection**.
- Stardrop will ask whether to install the mod immediately. Choose **Yes** and it places the mod in your active profile's mod folder.

1.5.2 Installing Manually

- Click **Add Mods** (or drag and drop a `.zip` file onto the Stardrop window).
- Stardrop extracts the archive and adds it to your mod list. If the archive contains multiple mods (common for framework requirements), Stardrop installs them all at once.

1.5.3 Enabling and Disabling Mods

- Each mod has a checkbox in the **Enabled** column. Unchecked mods are passed to SMAPI as disabled.
- Use **Shift+click** or **Ctrl+click** to bulk-enable or bulk-disable multiple mods at once.

1.5.4 Organizing with Mod Groups

Stardrop groups mods by their folder, content pack type, or category. To change the grouping:

1. Click the **Group By** dropdown in the toolbar.
2. Options include:
 - **Folder** — groups mods by their parent directory
 - **Content Pack** — groups mods by the framework they target (CP, JA, etc.)
 - **None** — flat list

For this guide, **Folder** grouping works best since each mod category maps to a clear folder structure.

1.6 Verifying Your Installation

Before diving in, run a quick sanity check:

1. In Stardrop, click the **SMAPI** button (or go to **Mods** → **Launch SMAPI**).

2. The SMAPI console opens and shows each mod being loaded. Watch for red `ERROR` or yellow `WARN` lines — they indicate broken dependencies or version mismatches.
3. Once the game reaches the title screen, quit. If SMAPI showed no errors, your setup is good.

1.6.1 Common Issues

Problem	Fix
Stardrop says SMAPI is missing	Re-run the SMAPI installer from smapi.io
Mod shows a red warning for missing dependencies	You missed a required framework mod — check the catalog entry's requirements
NXM downloads don't start	Re-authorize your Nexus API key in Nexus Mods → API Connection
Game crashes on launch	Disable all mods in Stardrop and enable them one category at a time
Stardrop won't launch	Install .NET 8 Runtime (required by Stardrop)
SMAPI console shows "Skipped" mods	These mods are disabled in Stardrop — enable them via the checkbox

1.7 Next Steps

With SMAPI and Stardrop ready, move to [02-vanilla-primer.md](#) for a crash course on playing Stardew Valley. If you already know the basics, jump straight into the mod catalog starting with [01-bugfixes.md](#).

2 Vanilla Primer: How to Play Stardew Valley

This chapter covers everything a first-time player needs to know to play Stardew Valley comfortably. The mod catalog later assumes you understand these basics, so read through even if you think you know the game — some 1.6 mechanics may be new to you.

2.1 Welcome to the Valley

Stardew Valley is a farming/life simulation RPG. You inherit your grandfather's overgrown farm in a small town called Pelican Town. What you do with it is up to you: grow crops, raise animals, mine for ore, befriend the locals, fight monsters, fish, cook, craft, and more. There is no wrong way to play, and there is no time limit — the story progresses at your pace.

The core loop: **use energy to do things** → **earn money** → **buy upgrades** → **unlock new things to do** → **repeat**.

2.2 Character Creation

When you start a new game, you choose:

- **Appearance, name, farm name, and favourite thing.** Favourite thing has a small effect on a late-game event — pick something funny.
- **Farm type.** This determines your farm map layout and gives a bonus to a specific skill:
 - **Standard Farm** — Largest open space. Best for new players.
 - **Riverland Farm** — Islands separated by water. Boosts fishing.
 - **Forest Farm** — Plenty of forage and hardwood stumps that regrow. Boosts foraging.
 - **Hill-Top Farm** — A quarry spawns on the farm. Boosts mining.
 - **Wilderness Farm** — Monsters appear at night. Boosts combat.
 - **Four Corners Farm** — Split into four themed quadrants. Designed for co-op, but fine solo.
 - **Beach Farm** — Large but sprinklers don't work on sand. Boosts fishing and foraging.
 - **Meadowlands Farm (1.6)** — Starts with a chicken coop and two chickens. Boosts farming.

Recommendation for first-timers: Standard Farm or Meadowlands Farm. The others add restrictions that make early-game harder.

2.3 The First Day

You arrive at Pelican Town on Spring 1, Year 1. Mayor Lewis greets you, gives you a brief tour, and leaves you at your overgrown farm. You have a small cabin, a few parsnip seeds, and 500 gold.

Do this on day 1:

1. Open your inventory and equip the hoe (right-click or X to place in your hands).
2. Hoe 15 tiles of dirt in front of your cabin.
3. Plant the 15 parsnip seeds and water them with your watering can.

4. Walk south into town and introduce yourself. You can explore until 2:00 AM — don't stay up past that or you'll pass out and lose money.

2.4 Understanding the Basics

2.4.1 Energy and Time

Your energy bar (lightning bolt icon, bottom-right) depletes as you use tools. If it hits zero, you move slowly and can't use tools. Eating food restores energy.

The day runs from 6:00 AM to 2:00 AM. **Go to bed before 2:00 AM** or you collapse and lose up to 10% of your gold (capped at 1,000g). Going to bed early is fine — waking up at 6:00 AM is automatic regardless of when you sleep.

The game saves when you sleep. There is no manual save.

2.4.2 Tools

You start with five tools:

Tool	Use	Upgrade
Hoe	Till soil for planting, dig up artifact spots	Hoe more tiles at once
Watering Can	Water crops	Water more tiles at once
Pickaxe	Break rocks, mine ore	Break rocks faster
Axe	Chop wood, clear stumps/logs	Chop faster, fell big stumps
Sword	Fight monsters in the mines (you get it on day 5)	Higher damage

Upgrade tools at Clint the blacksmith's shop by paying gold + ore. You must have the previous tier before upgrading to the next. Higher tiers let you charge your tool to affect more tiles (hoe/watering can) or break tougher objects (pickaxe/axe).

2.4.3 Skills

Every activity levels up a corresponding skill. Each skill has 10 levels. Every 5 levels you choose a **profession** — a permanent perk.

Skill	How to Level	Key Benefit
Farming	Harvest crops, pet animals	More produce, less energy use
Mining	Break rocks in the mines	More ore, gem rewards
Foraging	Pick up foraged items, chop wood	More items from wild plants
Fishing	Catch fish	Easier fishing minigame
Combat	Kill monsters in the mines	More damage, better loot

2.5 Skills in Detail

2.5.1 Farming

The main money-maker. Clear some land, hoe it, plant seeds, water daily, harvest when

ready. Water is the limiting factor early on — you can only water about 60–80 tiles before running out of energy.

Crop rules:

- Every crop has a **growth time** (in days) listed on the seed packet.
- Each season is 28 days. Seasonal crops die when the season changes.
- **Deadline:** If a seed packet says “8 days to grow”, plant it by Spring 21 at the latest to harvest before Summer.
- Crops need water every day except on rainy days — the game waters them for you.
- **Sprinklers** (unlocked at Farming level 2) automate watering. They are your top priority milestone.

Animals unlock later with barns and coops. Animals produce daily (milk, eggs, wool) and need petting for max happiness.

2.5.2 Mining

The mines are in the northeast, accessed via the mountain path. Enter any time after day 5 when you receive a letter from the Adventurer’s Guild.

- 120 floors, each procedurally generated.
- **Elevator** every 5 floors — use it to skip back to your deepest floor.
- Break rocks for stone, coal, copper, iron, gold, and gems.
- Every 10 floors, the ore tier changes: Copper (1–39), Iron (40–79), Gold (80–119), Iridium (120).
- **Combat tip:** Take food, watch your health, and don’t chase bats into crowds. The elevator is your safety net — leave before you die.
- Deeper floors have better ore. Prioritise reaching floor 80+ for consistent gold ore.

2.5.3 Foraging

Wild plants, berries, and tree seeds spawn across the map. Pick up everything you see. Foraging levels unlock:

- Level 1: Spring onions in the forest south of town
- Level 4: Salmonberries (Spring 15–18) and Blackberries (Fall 8–11) — these bush fruits are great early food
- Level 7: Winter roots and yams can be found by tilling dirt

Tapping trees (level 3) lets you place tappers for oak resin, maple syrup, and pine tar — essential for mid-game crafting.

2.5.4 Fishing

The most challenging skill early on. The fishing minigame has a green bar that you control. Fish move up and down; you keep the bar behind them to fill the progress meter.

- **Tackle** and **bait** make it easier. The Training Rod (buy from Willy) has a larger green bar for beginners.
- Each body of water (ocean, lake, river) has different fish.

- Fish sell for decent money. Fishing in the ocean or mountain lake is most profitable early on.
- **Crab pots** (level 3) are passive income — place them in water, check daily.

2.5.5 Combat

Fighting takes place in the mines. You get a starter sword from the Adventurer's Guild on day 5.

- **Sword:** Balanced — block with right-click.
- **Club:** Slow but high knockback.
- **Dagger:** Fast but short range.

Kill slimes, bugs, skeletons, and flying serpents. They drop loot you can sell or use for crafting. Levels 5 and 10 let you choose between a fighter and scout path — fighter is better on a first playthrough.

2.6 Money Making

Early game, you need gold for seeds, tool upgrades, and backpack expansion. Best sources in order:

1. **Fishing** — 300–500g per day if you're decent at the minigame.
2. **Crops** — Parsnips are cheap and fast; potatoes and cauliflower scale better. Once you can craft Quality Sprinklers (Farming level 6), farming becomes your main income.
3. **Foraging** — Free money. Spring onions (south of Marnie's ranch) sell for 40g each.
4. **Artisan goods** — Put crops in kegs (Farming level 8) and preserves jars (Farming level 4) for 2–3x the crop value.

Priority purchases:

1. Backpack upgrade (2,000g at Pierre's) — triples inventory space. Buy it day 2 or 3.
2. Copper watering can upgrade (2,000g + 5 copper bars) — lets you water 3 tiles at once.
3. Silo (100g, 10 stone, 5 copper bars, 10 clay) — lets you collect hay from grass for winter animals.

2.7 Relationships

Every NPC in Pelican Town has a **heart rating** (0–10, or 0–14 for your future spouse). Give them gifts they like on their birthday for 3x relationship points.

- **Talking** gives a small boost.
- **Gifts they love** give the most — check the wiki or experiment.
- **Gifts they hate** lose hearts.
- **Cutscenes** trigger at certain heart levels. Some are missable if you don't enter the right area on the right day.

Marriage is possible with 6 bachelors and 6 bachelorettes. Reach 8 hearts, give them a bouquet, reach 10 hearts, then give them a Mermaid's Pendant.

Important: NPCs have schedules — they move around based on day, weather, and season.

If you can't find someone, check their house, the saloon (evenings), or the wiki.

2.8 The Community Center

The central story goal. On Spring 5, you enter the run-down Community Center and find glowing golden scrolls — the Junimos. Repair the building by completing **bundles**: collect specific items (crops, fish, foraged goods, etc.) and place them on the scrolls.

- Completing a bundle rewards you with something useful (hearth upgrade, sprinkler, etc.).
- Completing all bundles in a room unlocks a major reward (e.g., the minecart network, greenhouse).
- Completing **all** bundles restores the Community Center and unlocks the endgame.

Alternative: Sell one crop bundle's worth of produce to JojaMart and buy a Joja membership. This turns every bundle into a cash payment (no item hunting). The cost totals ~140,000g. Doing so locks you out of the Community Center route permanently. Pick one on your first playthrough.

Bundle planning tip: Keep at least one of every crop, fish, and forage item you find. Put it in a chest and forget about it until you need it for a bundle.

2.9 Early Game Priorities

Your first spring, in rough order:

1. **Day 1–3:** Plant parsnips, buy more as soon as they sell. Buy the backpack upgrade.
2. **Day 5:** Enter the mines. Focus on reaching floor 5 for the elevator.
3. **Week 2:** Upgrade your backpack and watering can. Save 45 salmonberries on Spring 15–18 for infinite early energy.
4. **Week 3:** Upgrade the pickaxe or axe to copper. Push to floor 40+ in the mines.
5. **Week 4:** Make Quality Sprinklers your goal before Summer. Plant at least one of each seasonal crop for the Community Center.
6. **Summer 1:** Massively expand your farm using sprinklers. Blueberries are the best summer crop.

2.10 Seasons and Planning

The year runs Spring → Summer → Fall → Winter. Each season lasts 28 days.

- **Winter:** Crops don't grow outdoors. Use this time for mining, fishing, socialising, and upgrading tools. Foraging in winter (winter roots, yams, crystal fruit) is still profitable.
- **Seasonal prep:** On the 28th of any season, clear your fields. Dead crops don't need to be cleared — they vanish on the 1st.
- **Festivals** happen each season. They're optional but offer unique items and relationship opportunities.

2.11 Next Steps

Once you have a comfortable feel for the basics, you are ready to move from **Wave 1**

(enhanced vanilla) to **Wave 2** (content expansion). See [01-setup.md](#) for the full wave structure. Start with the Wave 2 graphics catalog sections in [03-mod-catalog/](#), then work through world expansion, new items, NPCs, and audio. Once those feel natural, [04-modded-gameplay.md](#) teaches the new mechanics each Wave 2 mod category introduces — and eventually Wave 3's gameplay overhauls.

3 Foundations

Prerequisite mods that other mods depend on. These must be installed first and load at the top of your mod list.

Mod	Purpose	Download	Required By
SMAPI	Mod loader for Stardew Valley	NexusMods	Everything
Content Patcher	Content framework for asset replacements	NexusMods	Most content mods
Content Patcher Animations	Animation support for CP	NexusMods	Animated content
Expanded Preconditions Utility	Advanced condition checking	NexusMods	Some content mods
SpaceCore	Core framework for many mods	NexusMods	Multiple mods
Json Assets	Custom item, fruit, and object framework	NexusMods	Many item mods
Farm Type Manager	Custom farm type / spawning framework	NexusMods	Custom farm maps
Extra Map Layers	Custom map layer framework	NexusMods	Map-expanding mods
Custom Music	Custom music playback	NexusMods	Music mods
SAAT	Audio API and toolkit	NexusMods	Audio mods
Alternative Textures	Texture replacement framework	NexusMods	Some graphics mods
Fashion Sense	Framework for larger accessories, hairstyles, hats, shirts, sleeves, pants, and shoes with animation support	NexusMods — SMAPI-based, v7.5.0+, 69k+ endorsements. Requires SMAPI.	FS clothing/hair packs
Positional Audio	Framework for positional audio — sounds that play from specific in-world locations	NexusMods — SMAPI-based, v1.0.3, 379 endorsements. Required by Now You Hear It.	Audio mods that use positional sound

Mod	Purpose	Download	Required By
Button's Extra Trigger Action Stuff (BETAS)	Trigger action framework used by custom NPCs and events	NexusMods — SMAPI-based, 1.6 Compatible. Framework mod. Requires SMAPI.	NPC mods that use BETAS
Midnight's Misc Tilesheets	Custom tilesheets used as a modder's resource by NPC and map mods	NexusMods — CP-based, 1.6 Compatible. Assets only.	Maps/NPCs that reference these tilesheets
Furniture Framework	Framework that adds new furniture items to the game via Content Patcher	NexusMods — CP-based. Needed by some furniture packs.	Furniture mods that use FF
Calcifer	Furniture catalogue framework for Content Patcher	NexusMods — CP-based. Needed by some furniture packs.	Furniture mods that use Calcifer
Em's Cows	Alternative Textures content pack adding 40+ cow skin variants	NexusMods — CP + AT-based, 1.6 Compatible. Requires Alternative Textures + CP + SMAPI. Parent mod for Em and Harry's Exotic Cattle.	Animal cosmetic mods that reference Em's cow variants
Console Commands	In-game console for debugging	Bundled with SMAPI	SMAPI utility
Error Handler	Friendly SMAPI error messages	Bundled with SMAPI	SMAPI utility

3.1 Load Order

These mods should always be enabled and loaded before any other mod. In Stardrop, use **Folder** grouping to keep foundations at the top of your mod list.

3.2 Notes

- Always install the latest SMAPI version compatible with SDV 1.6.15.
- When in doubt about a dependency, check the mod's Nexus description — most list their requirements clearly.
- Keep foundations up to date first before updating dependent mods.

4 Bugfixes

TODO: Write this section.

5 UI and HUD

Quality-of-life interface improvements and visual UI overhauls.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
NPC Map Locations	Shows the current location of every NPC on the world map. Hover over an icon to see their name; check the tooltip for their current schedule status.	NexusMods — CP-based, 85k+ endorsements. Does not reveal schedules ahead of time — only shows current position. Compatible with 1.6.	Below foundations, above content mods
Lookup Anything	Press F1 to see live info about whatever's under your cursor — crop harvest times, machine output, NPC gift tastes, animal happiness, fence durability, and more.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by Pathoschild, 193k+ endorsements. Updated for 1.6.15. Includes a progression mode (optional) that hides gift tastes until you've learned them naturally. Works in single-player and multiplayer.	After foundations, alongside other UI mods
UI Info Suite 2	Comprehensive info overlay — daily luck icon, dynamic experience bar, item tooltips with bundle/shipping/museum status, animal petting indicators, crop harvest times, sprinkler/scarecrow ranges, calendar and billboard anywhere, weather forecast, tool upgrade tracking, and more.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based, 43k+ endorsements. Every feature is individually toggleable in Generic Mod Config Menu. Defers to NPC Map Locations for map features when both are installed. Runs in single-player and multiplayer.	After foundations, alongside other UI mods

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
To-Dew	In-game to-do list with a configurable overlay that appears in the top-left corner during gameplay. Add, edit, and reorder tasks; data is saved to your save file.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by Jamie Taylor, 15.8k+ endorsements. Opens with a hotkey (default L). Integrates with the Mobile Phone mod. Compatible with 1.6.	After foundations, alongside other UI mods
Social Page Order Redux	Reorders the social tab so villagers are sorted by heart level (highest first). Groups NPCs by whether you've talked/gifted today for easier weekly planning.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based, 1.5k+ endorsements. Preserves vanilla look and feel. Compatible with 1.6.	After foundations, alongside other UI mods
DaisyNiko's Earthy Interface	Complete UI recolor with warm earthy tones — menus, dialogue boxes, inventory, shipping menu, calendar, and more. Matches the Earthy Recolour terrain palette.	NexusMods — CP-based by DaisyNiko, 20k+ endorsements. Companion to DaisyNiko's Earthy Recolour and Earthy Interiors. Compatible with 1.6. Toggle individual elements in config.	After other UI mods

5.1 Notes

- **NPC Map Locations** and **Lookup Anything** are standalone QoL mods that work well together — use F1 to look up an NPC, then check the map to find them.
- **Lookup Anything** has a configurable progression mode — enable it in Generic Mod Config Menu to preserve the discovery experience for gift tastes and recipes.
- **UI Info Suite 2** is a comprehensive info suite. Its NPC map feature is automatically disabled when NPC Map Locations is installed (the dedicated map mod takes priority). All features can be individually toggled in Generic Mod Config Menu if you prefer a more curated set of info displays.
- **To-Dew** and **Social Page Order Redux** are lightweight QoL mods that don't interact with other UI mods.
- **DaisyNiko's Earthy Interface** is designed to pair with DaisyNiko's Earthy Recolour (see 05-graphics-terrain.md) for a cohesive earthy aesthetic. Only use one full UI theme at a time.

6 Graphics Base

Base graphical overhauls that change buildings, paths, fences, and interior/exterior structures.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Medieval Buildings	Full set of seasonal farm buildings — barns, coops, silos, sheds, etc. Multiple style options.	NexusMods — CP-based. 32k+ endorsements. Pairs with Way Back Pelican Town for matching town buildings.	Above terrain/foilage mods
Way Back Pelican Town	Seasonal retexture of all town buildings, structures, and decor (including Desert + Ginger Island).	NexusMods — CP-based, tagged 1.6 Compatible. By Gweniaczek. Not fully compatible with SVE town map.	Same as Medieval Buildings
Gwen's Paths	Retextures/recolours of all craftable paths and floorings. CP and AT versions available.	NexusMods — Each path type toggleable in config. Matches Medieval Buildings aesthetic.	Below building mods
Cottagecore Fences	Seasonal retexture of wood, stone, iron, and hardwood fences. Adds vines, moss, and petals.	NexusMods — CP-based, confirmed 1.6 compatible. Also available as an AT pack.	Same as paths
Cuter Coops and Better Barns	Slightly larger, redecorated interiors for coops and barns.	NexusMods — CP-based. Changes interior maps — incompatible with other mods that modify barn/coop maps.	Below base graphics, above animal mods
Rustic Country Town Interiors	Recolors and redesigns town interiors, spouse rooms, and farm building interiors with seasonal decoration.	NexusMods — The official version is lagging behind 1.6. An unofficial 1.6 update is available. Alternative: DaisyNiko's Earthy Interiors is officially updated for 1.6.	Before farmhouse interior mods

6.0.1 Player Character Appearance

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Shardust's Animated Hairstyles	150+ animated hairstyles for Fashion Sense — some custom, some edited from game files. Colorable like vanilla hair.	NexusMods — FS-based, v18.0.0 (Jun 2026). 8k+ endorsements. Requires Fashion Sense.	After foundations, alongside other FS packs
Katy's Closet No.2	Themed outfits inspired by forest animals — 16 shirts, 8 skirts, 8 shorts, 16 hats, 3 accessories.	NexusMods — FS-based, Mar 2025. 3k+ endorsements. Requires Fashion Sense. Designed for GH's Peach Body Type (optional).	Same as other FS packs
Sugarmaple's Cafe Clothes	Coffee cafe-themed clothes — 7 shirts, 5 pants for Fashion Sense.	NexusMods — FS-based, Apr 2024. 7k+ endorsements. Requires Fashion Sense. Compatible with 1.6.	Same as other FS packs
Sugarmaple's Matcha Clothes	Matcha-themed pink and green clothes — 6 shirts, 4 pants, 3 hats.	NexusMods — FS-based, Apr 2024. 2.7k+ endorsements. Requires Fashion Sense. Companion to the Cafe Clothes set.	Same as other FS packs

6.0.2 Furniture

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Green Grove Furniture	100+ furniture pieces (couches, armchairs, tables, desks, rugs, decorations) with its own catalogue. Configurable color scheme (original/saturated).	NexusMods — CP-based, Feb 2025, 1k+ endorsements. Requires Calcifer + CP. Catalogue purchasable from Robin for 30,000g.	Below interior overhauls, above item mods

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
(CP)(FF) Retro Style Furniture	Retro-styled furniture set migrated from DGA to Furniture Framework. Functional lamps, windows, child beds, corkboards, and couches.	NexusMods — FF-based, Sep 2024, 1.6k+ endorsements. Requires Furniture Framework + CP + GMCM. Catalogue at Robin's shop.	Same as other furniture mods
(CP)(AT) Nostalgic Old Furniture Collection	Vintage/antique furniture with two modes: replace vanilla furniture or add as new items. Supports both CP and AT.	NexusMods — CP/AT-based, Apr 2024, 2.2k+ endorsements. Requires CP; AT optional. Configurable via GMCM. Double bed can't be shared with spouse in Add mode.	Below other furniture mods
Myc's Seasonal Fireplace	Seasonal stone fireplace with kettle and cauldron. Replaces the stone fireplace with seasonal decor. Also available as AT pack.	NexusMods — CP/AT-based, Mar 2024, 1k+ endorsements. Requires CP; AT optional. Replaces fireplace2 by default, configurable to replace any fireplace.	Same as other furniture mods

6.0.3 Player Equipment & Items

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Grandpa's Tools	Retextures all vanilla tools in a weathered, handcrafted style — axe, pickaxe, hoe, watering can, scythe, fishing rod, pan, and weapons. Matches the Medieval Craftables aesthetic.	NexusMods — CP-based by Gwениaczek & Stashek, 6k+ endorsements. Configurable per-tool toggles. Requires CP.	Below building textures, above item retextures

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Gwen's Medieval Craftables	Retextures all craftable equipment and machines — furnaces, kegs, preserve jars, chests, bee houses, scarecrows, sprinklers, and more. Medieval/fantasy aesthetic.	NexusMods — CP-based by Gwениaczek, 12k+ endorsements. Each machine type is individually toggleable in config. Pairs with Grandpa's Tools and Medieval Buildings for a cohesive look.	Same as Grandpa's Tools

6.1 Notes

- **Medieval Buildings** and **Way Back Pelican Town** are designed as a matching set (farm + town). You can mix them with other terrain recolours.
- **Cuter Coops and Better Barns** changes interior map dimensions — do not use with other mods that alter barn/coop maps.
- For **Rustic Country Town Interiors**, prefer the unofficial 1.6 update or Earthy Interiors for 1.6 compatibility.
- **Fashion Sense clothing/hair packs** all require the Fashion Sense framework (in Foundations). They can be mixed freely — Fashion Sense supports unlimited content packs simultaneously. Use the Hand Mirror tool (purchasable from Pierre or start with it during character creation) to equip items.
- **Furniture mods** that add new items require their respective frameworks (Calcifer for Green Grove, Furniture Framework for Retro Style). Nostalgic Old Furniture and Myc's Seasonal Fireplace work with CP alone.
- Most furniture mods add their own catalogue purchasable from Robin's shop. Items can also be spawned via CJB Item Spawner if preferred.

7 Graphics Portraits

Portrait replacements that change how NPCs look in dialogue and menu screens.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
mono's Portraits	A full portrait replacement for all vanilla villagers and marriage candidates, drawn at native scale with a faithful but distinct style. Includes winter outfits for 1.6.	NexusMods — CP-based, updated for 1.6. Does not cover modded NPCs.	Anywhere in graphics section

7.1 Notes

- Only one portrait mod can be active at a time per NPC. Choose one set that fits your preferred art style.
- Seasonal outfit variants (like mono's winter outfits) require the mod's config to be set correctly.

8 Graphics Terrain

Recolours and overhauls for outdoor tilesheets, foliage, grass, and overall world colour palette.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
DaisyNiko's Earthy Recolour	A warm, earth-toned recolor of all outdoor tilesheets. Includes custom trees, dig spots, grass, and revamped town buildings.	NexusMods — CP-based, updated for 1.6. 40k+ endorsements. Configurable options for grass, fruit trees, minimap, etc.	Load before building retextures
Way Back Pelican Town	Seasonal retexture of town buildings, structures, and decor. See entry in Graphics Base.	Listed in 03-graphics-base.md. Works best with vanilla or Earthy Recolour, Starblue, or Vibrant Pastoral.	Matches building retexture order
Natural Color - ReShade	An on-screen colour filter that adjusts saturation, contrast, lighting, and adds subtle chromatic aberration/tilt-shift.	NexusMods — Not a CP mod. Requires ReShade to be installed separately (external tool). Compatible with all mods and game versions. Configurable in-game with ReShade's UI.	Applies on top of all graphics mods

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Clear Glasses	SMAPI-based depixelation and visual enhancement — applies xBRZ smooth scaling to remove pixelation, plus configurable colour filters (saturation, brightness, temperature). Also improves load times by optimising texture caching.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by aurpine, 2k+ endorsements. Updated for 1.6. Configurable via GMCM. Alternative to ReShade-based approaches — works without external tools. Caution: can cause missing textures on some modded items; a lighter fork called Clear Monocle (performance-focused, xBRZ only) is available as an alternative.	After all graphics mods, same as ReShade presets

8.1 Notes

- **Terrain recolours** (like Earthy Recolour) change the colour palette of the world. Only use one outdoor recolor at a time.
- **ReShade presets** (like Natural Color) are screen-space filters that work on top of any mod combination. They require the ReShade injector tool.
- **Clear Glasses** achieves a similar visual result to ReShade presets but as a SMAPI mod — no external tools needed. It also provides load time improvements. If you use both, disable colour filters in one of them to avoid double-processing.
- **Way Back Pelican Town** had its terrain/building entry moved to 03-graphics-base.md but is referenced here as it pairs well with terrain recolours.

9 Graphics Animals

Mods that change the appearance of your pets, farm animals, horses, and wild critters.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Elle's Town Animals	Replaces nearly every creature in the valley — birds, squirrels, frogs, butterflies, Dusty, the traveling merchant's pig, and more. 42+ config options.	NexusMods — CP-based, 14k+ endorsements. Each critter type is individually toggleable in config.	Below base graphics, above animal additions
Elle's Cuter Cats	Adds up to 155 cat breeds/skins using the 1.6 pet breed system. Breeds include Bengal, Calico, Ragdoll, Siamese, Tuxedo, and more.	NexusMods — CP-based, 1.6-native. Uses the new breed feature instead of replacement. AT compatible.	Above animal replacements
Elle's Cuter Dogs	Adds up to 342 dog breeds/skins using the 1.6 pet breed system. Breeds include Corgi, Husky, Golden Retriever, Shiba Inu, and more.	NexusMods — CP-based, 1.6-native. Void variants included. AT compatible.	Same as Cuter Cats
Elle's Cuter Horses	79 horse skins with a choice of breed, saddle colour, and optional prismatic hair overlay.	NexusMods — CP-based. Standard texture replacement (no breed system for horses). Includes horse flute recolor.	Above other horse mods
SH's Wild Animals	Adds new wild animals to the world — squirrels, foxes, ducks, turtles, otters, platypuses, and more. Appear based on time, weather, and season.	NexusMods — CP-based. Main version includes SVE content; use the Lite version if not playing with SVE. May have minor performance impact with many animals on screen.	Load last in animal section

9.1 Notes

- **Elle's Town Animals** replaces existing critters; **SH's Wild Animals** adds new ones. They complement each other rather than conflict.
- **Elle's Cuter Cats/Dogs** use the 1.6 breed system, which adds options rather than

replacing sprites. On existing saves, use the debug command `debug cmenu` to change your first pet's appearance.

- **SH's Wild Animals** can cause lag on lower-end systems due to the number of active critters. Reduce the spawn rate in config if needed.
- For barn/coop animal skins, see [Elle's Cuter Barn Animals](#) and [Elle's Cuter Coop Animals](#) — companion mods from the same author.

10 World Expansion

TODO: Write this section.

11 Monsters and Combat

Quality-of-life improvements and visual tweaks for monster encounters.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Mini Bars	Adds customizable health bars above monsters. Shows remaining HP at a glance; supports different bar themes (mini/long), range-limiting, and toggle for showing only damaged enemies.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by GukelZ, 9.5k+ endorsements. Configurable via Generic Mod Config Menu or in-game commands. Compatible with Ridgeside Village and Swim mods. Updated for 1.6.	Below foundations

11.1 Notes

- **Mini Bars** is purely informational — it does not change monster stats or behaviour.

12 Items and Weapons

Visual retextures for items — rings, artifacts, minerals, fish, crops, artisan goods, food, and special items. These are purely cosmetic and do not change gameplay behaviour.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Better Rings	Retextures all ring sprites with cleaner, more detailed designs. Each ring type gets a distinct look.	NexusMods — CP-based by BBR, 1.7k+ endorsements. Pure visual replacement — no gameplay changes. Requires CP.	Above other item retextures
Fancy Artifacts Retexture	Retextures all artifact sprites — ancient dolls, skeletal remains, lost books, ornamental fans, and more.	NexusMods — CP-based by Aimon111, 4k+ endorsements. Keeps artifacts visually distinct and recognisable. Requires CP.	Above mineral retextures
DSHi Minerals Retexture	Retextures all gemstones, minerals, and geode-processed items — diamonds, prismatic shards, jade, frozen tears, and every geode mineral.	NexusMods — CP-based by DSHi. Part of the DSHi item retexture series. All DSHi mods share a consistent visual style.	After artifacts
DSHi Fish Retexture	Retextures all fish, trash, bait, and tackle items — every catchable fish, algae, seaweed, trash, and fishing equipment.	NexusMods — CP-based by DSHi. Companion to the other DSHi retextures for a unified item look.	After minerals
DSHi Shipping Items Retexture	Retextures crops, artisan goods, and forage — fruits, vegetables, flowers, wines, jellies, cheeses, and wild forageables.	NexusMods — CP-based by DSHi. Covers the most commonly shipped item categories.	After fish retextures
DSHi Food Retexture	Retextures concessions, desert festival foods, cooking ingredients, and prepared meals.	NexusMods — CP-based by DSHi. Pairs with the DSHi Shipping Items set for full item coverage.	After shipping retextures

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
DSHi Special Items Retexture	Retextures quest items, totems, wallet items, trinkets, and fertilizers.	NexusMods — CP-based by DSHi. Covers the remaining item categories not included in other DSHi packs.	After food retextures

12.1 Notes

- All items in this section are **purely cosmetic** — they replace sprite textures only and do not affect stats, recipes, or game mechanics.
- The **DSHi series** (5 mods) is designed as a cohesive set. Install all of them for a consistent visual style across every item category, or pick individual packs for specific item types. Load them in the order listed above.
- **Better Rings** can be used alongside the DSHi mods — they change different item categories.
- No Content Patcher conflicts between these mods — each targets distinct sprite sheets.

13 NPC Interactions

New NPCs, dialogue expansions, and social interaction enhancements.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Tilly the Tea-Loving Librarian	Adds a new marriageable NPC to Pelican Town — Tilly, a tea-loving bookworm who abandoned her failed business in Zuzu City. Includes custom location, heart events, dialogue, and schedule. Supports custom portraits (Nyapu-style optional).	NexusMods — CP + SMAPI-based, v2.7.5, 784+ endorsements. Requires Content Patcher, BETAS, and Midnight's Misc Tilesheets. GMCM recommended for Nyapu-style portrait and baby appearance configuration.	After foundations, alongside other NPC mods

13.1 Notes

- **Tilly** is a full custom NPC with marriage support, heart events, and a custom location. Install all required dependencies (BETAS, Midnight's Misc Tilesheets) before adding this mod.
- Only one portrait mod per NPC can be active at a time. Tilly includes optional Nyapu-style portrait support toggleable via GMCM.

14 Grownup Town

TODO: Write this section.

15 Gameplay Tweaks

Quality-of-life adjustments that streamline existing mechanics without adding new content.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Convenient Inventory	Inventory management suite — quick stack items to nearby chests, favorite items to protect them from being trashed/shipped/stacked, auto-organize chests, take all but one from a stack, and per-chest quick-stack toggles with priority levels.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by gaussfire, 24k+ endorsements. Full Generic Mod Config Menu support. Works with Chests Anywhere, Bigger Backpack, Custom Backpack Framework, and Convenient Chests 2. Compatible with 1.6.	Below foundations
Automatic Gates	Opens and closes gates automatically as you approach. Configurable delay, tile ignore list, and on-screen overlay.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by ScheKaa, 58k+ endorsements. Pure QoL — no gameplay changes. Compatible with 1.6.	Below foundations, alongside other gameplay tweaks
Destroyable Bushes	Destroy bushes with an axe. Bushes drop small amounts of wood and regrow after 3 days by default. Configurable damage, regrowth timer, drops, and which bush types can be destroyed.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by Esca-MMC, 22k+ endorsements. Full GMCM support. Designed for 1.6.15.	Below foundations, alongside other gameplay tweaks
Better Shipping Bin	Retrieve items you've placed in the shipping bin. Opens a chest-like menu showing all shipped items with ability to take them back.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by MindMeltMax, 3.9k+ endorsements. Configurable value banner and scroll direction. Compatible with 1.6.	Below foundations, alongside other gameplay tweaks

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Better Quest Rewards	Improves and balances quest rewards — configurable multipliers and reward pools for every quest type. All settings adjustable via config file or GMCM.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based, v1.1.0, 114+ endorsements. Requires SMAPI and GMCM. Tagged “Fair and balanced” — rewards are enhanced but not OP.	Below foundations, alongside other gameplay tweaks

15.1 Notes

- **Convenient Inventory** does not add items, change prices, or alter game balance — it only reduces the tedium of inventory sorting.
- **Better Quest Rewards** makes questing more satisfying without breaking progression. Configure the multiplier in GMCM if you prefer more conservative rewards.
- **Automatic Gates** is set-and-forget — install, run once to generate config, and gates open/close as you pass through. Optionally configure delays and ignored gates via overlay or GMCM.
- **Destroyable Bushes** lets you clear unwanted bushes without needing a map editor. Bushes regrow by default, so the landscape isn’t permanently altered. Configure which bush types and locations are affected in GMCM.
- **Better Shipping Bin** is purely a safety net for accidental shipping. Items can be retrieved until the day ends and they’re actually sold.

16 Skills and Professions

TODO: Write this section.

17 Farming and Making

New farm animals, machines, and crafting content that expand the farming experience.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Yet Another Harvest With Scythe Mod	Harvest all crops and forage using the scythe instead of hand-plucking. Highly configurable per crop type — choose which can be scythed vs hand-picked, or allow swords as scythes.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by bcmpinc, 40k+ endorsements. Requires StardewHack. Options for flowers, forage, and plucking while scythe-equipped. Compatible with 1.6.	After foundations, alongside other farming mods
Immersive Sprinklers and Scarecrows	Place sprinklers and scarecrows at the intersection of crop tiles instead of on dedicated tiles. Sprinklers can hold both an enricher and a pressure nozzle simultaneously.	NexusMods — SMAPI-based by aedenthorn, 298+ endorsements. Replaces the older Immersive Sprinklers mod. Full GMCM support. Compatible with 1.6.	After foundations, alongside other farming mods
Em's Hedgehogs	Adds hedgehogs as a new coop animal. Hedgehogs need grass and a safe coop to sleep; every other morning they leave a piece of gathered fruit (plum, apricot, blackberry, or salmonberry).	NexusMods — CP-based. Requires Content Patcher. Simple, cute addition — no new buildings or items needed.	After foundations, alongside other animal content mods
Em's Cows	Adds 40+ real-life cow breed skins as Alternative Textures options for your barn cows. Choose from Holstein, Angus, Jersey, Highland, Belted Galloway, and many more.	NexusMods — CP + AT-based, 1.6 Compatible. Requires Content Patcher, Alternative Textures, and SMAPI. Parent mod for Em and Harry's Exotic Cattle.	Above animal content mods that reference these breeds

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Em and Harry's Exotic Cattle	Turns the rarer cow breeds from Em's Cows into distinct barn animals with their own produce. If you love Em's Cows but want exotic breeds to feel special, this mod gives them unique products and behaviour.	NexusMods — CP-based, 1.6 Compatible. Requires Em's Cows and Content Patcher. Compatible with Alternative Textures.	After Em's Cows

17.1 Notes

- **Yet Another Harvest With Scythe Mod** requires **StardewHack** (a library mod from the same author). Configure which crops are scythe-harvestable vs hand-pick-only in GMCM. Known incompatibility with Tractor Mod.
- **Immersive Sprinklers and Scarecrows** replaces both the older Immersive Sprinklers and Immersive Scarecrows mods — objects placed with the old mods won't carry over. Saves objects in location data so hoe dirt removal won't break them.
- **Em's Hedgehogs** only need a regular coop — no extra buildings required. The fruit they gather is seasonal and varies by what's available.
- **Em's Cows** is a visual alt-textures pack first, but also serves as the dependency for Em and Harry's Exotic Cattle which turns rare breeds into separate gameplay-relevant animals.
- Install in order: Em's Cows → Em and Harry's Exotic Cattle. Hedgehogs are independent and can be installed at any time.

18 Music and Audio

Mods that add or replace music tracks, ambient sounds, and audio effects.

Mod	Purpose	Notes	Load Order
Now You Hear It	Adds positional sounds to activities and objects that you'd expect to make noise — footsteps on different surfaces, tools interacting with materials, environmental rustling, and more. All sounds play from in-world positions for a more immersive audio experience.	NexusMods — CP-based, v1.2.2, 349+ endorsements. Requires Content Patcher and Positional Audio. SpaceCore optional for additional sound effects.	After foundations (after Positional Audio)

18.1 Notes

- **Now You Hear It** depends on the **Positional Audio** framework (listed in Foundations). Install that first.
- SpaceCore is listed as optional but recommended by the mod author for additional sound coverage.
- This mod is purely auditory — it adds no gameplay mechanics, items, or UI changes.

19 Modded Gameplay: What Changes and How to Play

This chapter covers the new mechanics, systems, and content added by the modlist across Waves 2 and 3. Each section assumes you have already installed the corresponding mod catalog categories and understand the vanilla mechanics from [02-vanilla-primer.md](#). If something here references a mod you haven't installed yet, jump back to that category in [03-mod-catalog/](#) first.

19.1 Wave 2 — Content Expansion

Wave 2 adds new things to discover, explore, and interact with. The core game loop (farm → mine → craft → build relationships → repeat) stays the same — there's just more of everything.

19.1.1 Graphics Overhaul (Categories 03–06)

Graphics mods don't change gameplay, but they change how you see the game. The visual overhaul spans four categories:

- **03 — Graphics Base:** Foundational texture replacements that set the art style for the entire world.
- **04 — Graphics Portraits:** Character portrait replacements that give every NPC a more expressive, detailed look.
- **05 — Graphics Terrain:** Map and terrain textures — grass, dirt, water, paths, trees. This is the biggest visual change.
- **06 — Graphics Animals:** Farm animals, pets, wildlife, and monsters get visual upgrades.

What to expect: The game looks significantly different from vanilla screenshots you may have seen. Colors may be warmer or more saturated, character expressions may feel more personal, and some locations may look unfamiliar at first. Walk around Pelican Town on Day 1 to re-orient yourself — everything is in the same place, it just looks different.

Performance note: Graphics mods are the heaviest category on GPU memory, especially at 4K. If your framerate drops or load times spike, reduce your resolution or selectively disable terrain textures first (they have the largest impact). See [performance/03-mod-impact.md](#) for benchmarks.

19.1.2 World Expansion (Category 07)

New areas, villages, and locations are added to the map. These may be accessible through previously blocked-off paths, new NPC events, or transport systems you unlock through gameplay.

What to expect:

- New areas often introduce **new NPCs** with their own schedules, heart events, and gift preferences. Treat them like any other villager — talk to them, give gifts, watch for heart events.

- Some expanded areas have **new shops** selling unique items. Check these regularly.
- Expanded areas may add **new forage spots, fishing locations, and mining nodes**. Re-explore old routes — the new content is often tucked into places you stopped visiting.
- **Time investment:** Exploring every new area can take an in-game season. Don't rush. The content isn't going anywhere.

Key mechanic: Several expansion mods gate areas behind **Community Center progress, heart levels, or seasonal events**. If an area seems inaccessible, you probably haven't met the unlock condition. Keep playing.

19.1.3 Monsters and Combat (Category 08)

New enemy types appear in the mines, in expanded areas, and potentially on your farm (if using the Wilderness farm map). Combat difficulty scales up compared to vanilla.

What to expect:

- New monsters have **unique attack patterns** — don't assume the vanilla dodge-then-swing rhythm works on everything. Watch their telegraphs.
- Some monsters have **elemental resistances or weaknesses**. A sword that melted slimes in vanilla may bounce off a new enemy type. Experiment with weapon types.
- **Boss variants** of existing enemies may appear on deeper mine floors or in special encounters. These hit harder and have more health.
- New monster loot feeds into Wave 2's **Item and Weapons** category — what drops is often the key ingredient for new equipment.

Tips: - Bring more food than you think you need. New monsters hit harder. - Upgrade your weapon one tier earlier than you would in vanilla. - If a new enemy one-shots you, you're under-geared. Go back to the previous tier, craft better equipment, and try again.

19.1.4 Items and Weapons (Category 09)

New weapons, rings, consumables, and crafting materials expand your combat and utility options. This category adds depth without breaking balance — nothing here is a cheat weapon.

What to expect:

- New **weapon types** may fill niches the vanilla sword/club/dagger trio doesn't cover.
- New **rings** stack with existing effects. You can wear two rings in vanilla; modded rings may unlock additional slots or combine effects.
- New **consumables** (elixirs, tonics, special foods) give temporary buffs beyond vanilla's food buffs. Buff stacking rules still apply — same-stat buffs overwrite, different stats stack.
- Some new items are **crafted from monster drops** introduced in Category 08. If you can't craft something, you need to hunt the monster that drops its component.

Tips: - Read item tooltips carefully — modded items often have effects that aren't obvious from their icon. - Sell nothing marked "crafting material" until you know what it builds. - The Adventurer's Guild may sell new weapons after you defeat certain new monster types.

19.1.5 NPC Interactions (Category 10)

Expanded dialogue, new heart events, and deeper character arcs for vanilla NPCs. Some mods in this category add entirely new NPCs with full storylines.

What to expect:

- Vanilla NPCs have **many more lines of dialogue**. Talking to them daily actually gives new conversations instead of repeats. This matters — you learn more about their personalities and backstories.
- **New heart events** trigger at levels that were previously empty in vanilla. Revisit familiar characters after reaching the next heart threshold.
- New NPCs follow the same rules as vanilla: **talk daily, give loved gifts, trigger heart events, repeat**. Their schedules vary by season and weather — use the same strategies you learned in the vanilla primer.
- Some mods add **platonic and romantic dialogue paths** that diverge based on your choices in heart events. Your responses matter.

Tips: - Don't skip dialogue just because you "know" the character from vanilla — the modded version may surprise you. - New NPCs have their own gift preferences. Experiment, or check the mod's documentation (not the vanilla wiki).

19.1.6 Grown-Up Town (Category 11)

Tasteful mature content — expanded dating dialogue, seasonal outfits, suggestive-but-tasteful event scenes, and relationship depth that acknowledges the player character as an adult.

What to expect:

- **Dating dialogue** is more mature and varied. Characters express attraction, vulnerability, and intimacy in ways vanilla only hints at.
- **Seasonal outfits** change how NPCs look throughout the year, adding visual variety to daily interactions.
- Some events have **mature themes** (implied intimacy, relationship milestones). Nothing is explicit or pornographic — the guide deliberately excludes that content.

Tips: - This content is optional. If a mod in this category makes you uncomfortable, disable it — nothing else depends on it. - Most mature content triggers at higher heart levels (6+ hearts), so it won't ambush a new player.

19.1.7 Music and Audio (Category 15)

New soundtrack tracks, ambient soundscapes, and audio enhancements that replace or supplement vanilla's music.

What to expect:

- **Location-specific music** may change. Familiar areas now have new themes.
- **Season-specific tracks** give each season a distinct sonic identity.
- **Event music** (festivals, heart events) may have new compositions.
- Some mods add **ambient sounds** (birds, wind, water) that play alongside music.

No new mechanics to learn — just listen and enjoy. If a track isn't to your taste, audio mods can be disabled individually without affecting anything else.

19.2 Wave 3 — Gameplay Overhaul

Wave 3 changes *how* the game plays. Skills work differently, professions have new paths, farming and crafting are expanded, and core balance is shifted. **Do not install Wave 3 mods before you've played extensively with Waves 1 and 2.** These mods assume you know vanilla's numbers well enough to appreciate what changed.

19.2.1 Gameplay Tweaks (Category 12)

Balance adjustments, quality-of-life features that go deeper than UI changes, and subtle mechanical reworks. This category walks the line between "enhancement" and "overhaul."

What to expect:

- **Economy rebalancing:** Crop sell prices, seed costs, and upgrade costs may shift. Don't rely on vanilla wiki numbers for profit calculations.
- **Tool and weapon balance:** Upgrades may have different costs, effects, or requirements. Check the mod documentation before spending resources.
- **Quality-of-life rules:** Some mods adjust how time passes indoors, how long buffs last, or how inventory stacks work. These feel subtle until you go back to vanilla and notice their absence.
- **New game rules:** Some tweaks add entirely new systems — mail-order delivery, crafting from storage chests, or season-specific bonuses.

Tips: - Read every mod's Nexus description before installing. Gameplay tweaks are the category where "I'll figure it out in-game" leads to frustration. - Test one tweak at a time if you're unsure. These mods rarely conflict, but their combined effect can shift game balance significantly.

19.2.2 Skills and Professions (Category 13)

Overhauled skill trees, new professions, and sometimes entirely new skills. This category fundamentally changes character progression.

What to expect:

- **Expanded skill trees:** Vanilla skills may extend past level 10, with additional profession choices at new thresholds.
- **New skills:** Entirely new skill categories (e.g., cooking, luck, archaeology) may be added alongside the five vanilla skills. These level up through their own activities.
- **Profession reworks:** Vanilla profession choices may be rebalanced, replaced, or supplemented with new options. Don't pick a profession on autopilot — read the new options carefully.
- **Prestige systems:** Some mods add a "prestige" mechanic — after maxing a skill, you can reset it for permanent bonuses and start again.

Tips: - Skill overhauls are the most complex category in the modlist. Before installing, read the mod's documentation thoroughly. - New skills interact with other Wave 3 mods. A

“cooking” skill, for example, ties directly into Farming and Making (Category 14) mods. - Profession choices in overhauled systems are often **permanent** — there’s no Statue of Uncertainty for modded professions. Choose deliberately.

19.2.3 Farming and Making (Category 14)

Expanded crafting recipes, new cooking systems, additional crops and artisan goods, and deeper farming mechanics.

What to expect:

- **New crops** across all seasons with unique growth times, profit curves, and processing options. Don’t assume vanilla’s “blueberries in summer, cranberries in fall” shorthand still applies.
- **Expanded artisan production:** New machines (distillers, smokers, dryers) process goods in ways vanilla doesn’t. Each has its own input/output rules.
- **New cooking recipes** that use modded ingredients from new crops and expanded foraging.
- **Crafting expansions:** New craftable machines, decorative items, and utility objects.
- **Animal products** may have new processing paths (artisan cheeses beyond cheese, flavored honeys, specialty wools).

Tips: - This category adds the most items to learn. Keep a chest labeled “New Stuff” and dump anything unfamiliar into it until you understand its use. - Processing chains can be longer than vanilla’s “fruit → keg → wine.” Plan your layout with room for intermediate machines. - New crops may have **soil or season requirements** vanilla crops don’t. Read seed descriptions.

19.3 Wave Progression Checklist

Use this as a rough guide for when to move between waves. There is no strict timer — play at your own pace.

Milestone	Wave Status
Installed SMAPI and Stardrop, Foundations mods active	Ready for Wave 1
Reached Summer Year 1, comfortable with all five vanilla skills	Wave 1 is working
Completed at least 2 Community Center rooms	You know vanilla well enough
Reached Year 2, finished the Community Center	Ready for Wave 2
Explored all Wave 2 expansion areas	Wave 2 is working
Maxed vanilla skills (level 10 in all five)	You know the game deeply
Killed every new monster type from Category 08	Combat is comfortable

Milestone	Wave Status
Seen new NPC heart events through at least 8 hearts	Relationships are familiar
Completed the Community Center or Joja route on a Wave 2 save	Ready for Wave 3

Important: Wave 3 mods may require a new save. Many skill and profession overhauls don't apply cleanly to existing saves — check each mod's documentation for save-compatibility notes.

19.4 Next Steps

With the mechanics understood, the final chapter [05-mod-manager-setup.md](#) covers Stardrop mod management — profiles, mod groups, filtering, and tips for keeping your mod list organized.

20 Stardrop Mod Management

Stardrop keeps your mod list organized through profiles, mod groups, and filtering — no manual separator setup needed. This chapter covers how to use Stardrop's features to manage the mod catalog efficiently.

20.1 Profiles

Profiles let you maintain separate mod lists for different playthroughs. For this guide, you should already have created a profile named `SDV Modlist Guide` during setup.

20.1.1 Managing Profiles

- **Create:** Profiles → Manage Profiles → New
- **Switch:** Select a profile from the dropdown in the toolbar
- **Profile-specific configs:** Enable in Settings → Enable Profile Specific Mod Configs. This keeps each mod's `config.json` separate per profile — useful if you want different settings for different playthroughs.
- **Export/Import:** Right-click a profile in the manager to export or import it. Exported profiles can be shared or backed up.

20.1.2 Why Profiles Matter

The three-wave approach in this guide naturally maps to profiles:

- **Wave 1 profile:** Only foundations, bugfixes, and UI/HUD mods enabled
- **Wave 2 profile:** Add graphics, world expansion, and content mods
- **Wave 3 profile:** Full modlist with gameplay overhauls

You can maintain a single profile and simply enable/disable categories as you progress, or create separate profiles to preserve state at each milestone.

20.2 Mod Groups

Stardrop's **Group By** feature organizes mods into collapsible sections — functionally equivalent to the separators used in other mod managers.

20.2.1 Grouping Options

Option	Behavior	Best For
Folder	Groups by the mod's parent directory	Mirroring the mod catalog's category structure
Content Pack	Groups by target framework (CP, JA, etc.)	Seeing which framework each mod uses
None	Flat alphabetical list	Quick searching

For this guide, **Folder** grouping is recommended. Install each mod category into its own folder structure (Stardrop does this automatically when you install a mod), and the grouping will match the catalog's chapter layout.

20.2.2 Collapsing and Expanding

Click the **collapse/expand** button next to a group header to hide or show its contents. This keeps your list manageable when you have many mods installed.

20.3 Filtering

The filter bar at the top of the mod list lets you quickly narrow down what you see.

20.3.1 Built-in Filters

Filter	What It Shows
All Mods	Every mod in your profile
Enabled Mods	Only checked (active) mods
Disabled Mods	Only unchecked (inactive) mods
Updatable Mods	Mods with available updates
Configurable Mods	Mods that have a <code>config.json</code> you can edit

20.3.2 Search

Type in the search box to filter by mod name, author, or folder. The search is case-insensitive and updates in real time.

20.3.3 Right-Click Filtering

Right-click any mod to filter the list by its folder or content pack type — useful for seeing all mods in the same category.

20.4 Themes

Stardrop ships with several built-in themes. Change them via **View** → **Themes**.

Theme	Style
Default	Light, clean interface
Dark Mode	Dark background, reduced eye strain
Catppuccin Mocha	Warm dark theme with muted accents
(several others)	Available in the themes submenu

Choose whatever is comfortable for extended modding sessions.

20.5 Nexus Integration

Stardrop's Nexus integration goes beyond just downloading mods:

- **Endorse mods** directly from Stardrop (right-click a mod → Open Mod Page → Endorse)
- **One-click updates** for Nexus Premium users (right-click → Install Update)
- **NXM handler** captures "Download with Mod Manager" clicks from your browser

If the NXM handler stops working, re-authenticate in **Nexus Mods** → **API Connection**.

20.6 Tips

- **Check for updates regularly:** Stardrop checks for mod updates on launch. You can also force a check via **Mods** → **Check for Mod Updates**.
- **Use notes:** Right-click a mod → Add/Edit Notes to record why you installed it or any configuration changes you made. Notes are tied to the active profile.
- **Custom columns:** Right-click the column headers to show or hide columns (Requirements, Install Timestamp, Last Updated, etc.).
- **Backup your profile:** Export your profile via Profiles → Manage Profiles → Export after setting up each wave. This makes recovery trivial.
- **Keep Stardrop updated:** Stardrop notifies you when a new version is available. You can update from within the app or download manually from the [Nexus page](#).